**The Story of Hwa Lee – the Profile of a Three-Self Pastor**

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by Luis Bush

**Introduction**

The first morning in Beijing on November 10, a small delegation went to visit the Chongwenmen Church, which is one of the largest Christian Protestant churches in Beijing. When first established in 1870, the church was called Asbury Church. During the Boxer Rebellion of 1900, it fell victim to the rage of China's farmers and was burned down completely. In 1902, the government provided funds to rebuild the Asbury Church and completed the new construction in 1904. Since its establishment, the church has been one of the most important and famous in Beijing.




In the main sanctuary, a large number of members gathered for prayer. The spirited prayer and Bible teaching with conviction were testimony to a church alive in the heart of the city.



We came across one of the lead pastors by the name of Hwa Lee, who kindly accepted the invitation to be asked a few questions. The story of Hwa Lee turned out to be one of the highlights of my time in China as it revealed the spiritual vitality of not only a Three-Self pastor but also of a Three-Self church.

**Anhui Province: The Early Years (1981-1999)**

As a boy, Hwa Lee did not like to study and was very mischievous. In his second year of high school, he became a good athlete. He enjoyed different sports. The school he attended was planning to send him to an athletic college. Hwa Lee was very energetic and in good health. So it was very unexpected when one day after his final exams, he collapsed on the floor. He was 18 years old at the time. This turned out to be the turning point of his life. Through it he was born again. This happened because of his mother. She slept below him. Hwa Lee shook the bed, and his mother heard it on the floor below. That was how he communicated with her. His mother came up quickly. When she saw Hwa Lee and the blood in front of him, she reacted in a way that surprised him. He was eager to see her so that she might take him to the hospital or comfort him.

Instead of everything he had hoped she would do to help out, his mother took off her shoes and started to pray. “I was very angry,” he said. “Why did she not do anything for me?”
At that time, although he was very disappointed, he still felt that she loved him. Hwa Lee watched her calm demeanor as he was vomiting blood. Seeing her pray, he expressed: “My heart was deeply touched.” He used to believe that God did not exist. Now he felt he must believe in Him because his mother could not be “speaking to the air,” which was the impression he had watching her pray. That is when he realized “I was spiritually reborn.” He made a decision to receive Christ as His Savior. It was the summer of 1999, and he was 18 years old.

**Anhui: New Life in Christ – Old Things had Gone, New Things had Come**



Many things changed after that. First, Hwa Lee's relationship with his mother changed. He had many conflicts with her in the past. In China, he shared, “we believe in science more than in God.” Every time his mother prayed before a meal, he felt very strange when she gave thanks. “I thought it strange that she would pray this way. How could it be that she really believed the meal would come down from heaven when it was obvious it came because of the hard work of my father? So I used to do something. When my mother prayed at the meal table, I would take away her meal. I told her: 'If you pray, you get no meal.'” He remembered the night when he kept vomiting blood. He had wondered why this could happen to his mother if God, in fact, did exist. It seemed unfair. She had been serving God. This was her son who was so sick. He said he felt like Jacob the night he wrestled with the angel until daybreak. Now, at last, he felt close to his own mother.

Second, Hwa Lee's relationship with God changed. He revealed: “I had hated God because He took so much of my mother’s time.” God occupied all her time it seemed. He was jealous that she would give so much of her time to God and not to him. His classmates’ mothers treated them better than his own mother treated him. She led the choir and participated in music festival. “I hated God for taking my mother’s time.” Now, he loved God. It was a new day for Hwa Lee.
Third, his father’s relationship with God changed. His dad did not believe in God until he saw “the action of God in my body.” The Chinese people believe what they see in the natural. “Although we believe in science, we also believe what we see.” Everyone could see the changes in Hwa Lee's body, and they believed when they saw the change in him. Many university students received their education without having any faith in God. “My father became a believer in 1999 at the same time as I did. In fact, my teachers began to believe in God and so did two or three of my classmates.
“The fourth change was in my own life. I had always been a poor student and a troublemaker in class. I sat in the back of the class and caused trouble. We founded an organization of trouble

makers. We would walk around with these long knives. Forty students became members of my group. We used to like to fight with new people." What kind of a knife? "It was a watermelon cutting kind of a knife. But we would not use it on people. We would just pretend to threaten them with it. After I came to faith in Christ, I continued to be the leader of the group but did not do anything wrong. I started to talk about the Bible and read the Bible to my friends. Several of the guys became believers in Christ." For Hwa Lee, all things had become new.

**Anhui: A Period of Study (1999-2004)**

"Between that time in 1999 until today, eleven years have passed. After coming to faith in Christ, there was only one thing I wanted to do – that was to read the Bible. The church I used to go to was in the village. The preacher could not read very well. I asked myself what I shall do with my life since God healed me in such a miraculous way. Maybe I could learn the Bible and help in that church in Anhui in Southern China. It is the same place that President Tao of China came from. I went to a seminary in Anhui for three years so that I could help in the church."

**Nanjing: Nanjing Seminary (2005-2007)**

"I served in the local church there for one year and then went to Nanjing Seminary in 2005 for two more years of study at the main seminary of the Three-Self Church in China. Nanjing Seminary is not what many people describe. About 70% of the student body believe God with a strong faith. The other 30% do not. I struggled for a while at Nanjing Seminary when I heard liberal theology taught, but I learned to separate what I was learning from my faith in Christ. If you think you believe in Christ and are changed by liberal theology, then your faith in Christ is not genuine. But if you can learn from different kinds of theology and still believe in God, then it can be beneficial. I graduated in 2007 after five years of study in seminary."

**Beijing: the Profile of a Three-Self Church (2007-present)**

"I came to this church as a member of the pastoral staff after graduation and have been serving here for four years. When I arrived, there were 3000 members. Today there are around 6000 members. Every Sunday we have about 70 newcomers. We emphasize the Good News of Jesus Christ and invite people to come to Christ."

Why this sudden growth in membership? "The Chinese culture, "explained Hwa Lee, "is in rapid reformation. In the past thirty years, the moral standard has been getting worse. You can see this in relationships between people. Many Chinese people's hearts are empty. Many people are aware they have to believe. They must have faith. Why do they come to church? Many young people come to Beijing because it's the capital of China. They come to see if they can make their dreams come true. Beijing is big but cold inside. The distance between people is very wide. They experience much stress and great pressure every day. People need comfort. They need love. The church is the best option for the people of China. The church is becoming more important to people all the time. Every morning, people come for Bible study in the Three-Self church like this one from Tuesday to Thursday.

"Now I am one of the leaders of our staff of 11 serving in this church. There are about 200 Gen Y'ers (age 15 to 24) and about 100 4/14'ers. The church has a robust prayer life, as we saw first-

hand at mid-morning. Mainly the older members come for morning prayers, as we observed as they came out of the service.

“We have five services on Sunday. At 2 pm there is a college and career class with about 100 people. Most of the members of the church have graduated from university. In the past they had little education.

“Each week we have an outreach into the central business district of Beijing, which is nearby. We offer different activities there and hand out pamphlets. People are open.”

**Beijing: Home Group Plan Experiences Vitality of Faith**



Pastor Lee is one of the key pastors in church in charge of the training of the whole church. He designed the group family plan in early 2011. The church was divided into cell groups according to the region where people live in Beijing. The two maps of Beijing identify the locations of the cell groups with a listing of the names of group leaders and the address. Now there are 60 groups, according to Pastor Lee. He teaches the leaders every Wednesday and bases the lesson on the Sunday morning sermon. The home groups are mainly for discussion. The leaders are mostly women. What about other Three-Self churches? Pastor Lee answered that many are experiencing the same kind of spiritual vitality as Chongwenmen Church. Perhaps it’s a new day not only in the life of Hwa Lee, not only in the life of the oldest-led Three-Self church in Beijing but in the Three-Self Church in China!

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